

Sophia R.C. Lander

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Education

University of Texas at Austin

Aug 2025 – Present

PhD, Government and Masters of Science in Statistics

- First Year Advisor: Rachel Wellhausen (Primary), Nate Jensen (Secondary)

Columbia University

Sept 2021 – May 2025

B.A., Political Science

- Undergraduate Thesis Advisor: Calvin Thrall
- Departmental Honors in Political Science
- GPA: 3.9/4.0

Experience

Strategy Intern

Washington D.C.

Metrea

May 2024 – Aug 2024

- Worked to develop potential new Department of Defense innovation contracts
- Researched ongoing political trends in targeted areas of company operations in the South China Sea
- Gain expertise in wargaming, simulations, and budget analysis
- Internship culminated in a capstone project which modeled deception "as-a-service" using game theory tools presented the MORS Emerging Techniques Forum

Civil Immigration and Housing Intern

New York, NY

The Legal Aid Society of New York

Sept 2023 – May 2024

- Worked directly with the Deputy Director of Community Outreach to create new ways to introduce updated immigration resources and housing rights to underprivileged New Yorkers
- Resulted in new "Know Your Rights" campaigns for LAS
- Handled client intake for Temporary Protective Status immigration clients

Track II Dialogue Program Assistant

New York, NY

The National Committee on U.S.-China Relations

May 2023 - Aug 2023

- Assisted with running the Healthcare, Climate Finance, and Maritime Law Track II Dialogues
- Helped to write literature reviews for the dialogue participants and summarized their discussions in consensus documents.

Electronic Discovery and Litigation Support Intern

New York, NY

Sullivan & Cromwell LLC

May 2022 - Aug 2022

- Gained experience in data management, security, and prioritization
- Worked to develop a new website database for in-house evidence productions
- Developed communication and critical thinking skills from having to work in a large corporate firm

Publications - Peer Reviewed

Publications - Other

A BIT of Regret: Modeling the Development Consequences of Investor-State Dispute Settlement

May 2025

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Columbia University Academic Commons

Deception as a Successful Deterrent of Aggressive Action: A Game Theory Approach to Wargaming

Nov 2024

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Presented at the Military Operations Research Society's Emerging Techniques Form. Winner of the 2024 Visco Prize. Available Upon Request.

Firms as Legal Fiction: Closing the North-South Divide by Reforming Investor State Dispute Settlement

Feb 2024

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Presented at the Pi Sigma Alpha National Conference in Washington D.C.

Working Papers

Innovative Winners: Variation of Technological Innovation and Fitness in Public-Private Partnerships (Agent Based Modeling and Simulation Techniques)

April 2026

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Lawfare: Home State Politicization of Investor-Disputes and Wartime Norm Violation

October 2025

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Public Perception and ESG Disclosures: Modeling the Political Nature of Disclosure Regimes on Private Equity Acquisitions

May 2025

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Teaching

Research Assistant: Prof. Michael Findley

Oct 2025 - Present

- External Validity App Design: Working to design and develop an app for practitioners of experiments/causal inference in the social sciences.
- Seeks to give researchers the tools to improve their study's applicability to broader scope conditions through the use of modeling and simulations, optimization, and theory building exercises like causal cakes and DAGs.

Conferences, Workshops, Talks

Innovative Winners: Variation of Technological Innovation and Fitness in Public-Private Partnerships: INFORMS Analytics Conference, National Harbor, MD. April 2026

The Operations Research Society's 42nd International Symposium of Military Operational Research: Eugene Visco Prize Presenter, July 2025

Military Operations Research Society (MORS) Emerging Techniques Forum: Eugene Visco Prize Winner, December 2024

Pi Sigma Alpha National Conference: February 2024, February 2025

Awards, Grants, Fellowships

Awards: Eugene Visco Prize for Best Paper and Presentation, MORS, Dec 2024 (\$3,500)

Fellowships: Howard Penniman Graduate Scholarship, Pi Sigma Alpha, July 2025 (\$2,000) ; PhD Research Excellent Program 2 Fellowship, May 2025, (\$9,000)

Skills and Languages

Coding: R (proficient), Python (proficient), Mathematica (proficient), LaTeX (proficient), NetLogo (semi-proficient)

Languages: Mandarin Chinese (limited working proficiency), German (limited working proficiency)

References

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University of Texas at Austin
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Calvin Thrall
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